

R13 Engaging Leadership in Reflection

Pillar	Reflection	Difficulty	Level 2
Time Required	40-50 minutes	Group Size	Leadership team (3-8)
Mode	Leader facilitation (leaders reflecting on their own practice)	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	None (but leaders should understand what they're asking teams to do before modelling it)	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Leaders not participating in reflection, team reflection feels like a directive from leaders who don't do it themselves, reflection seen as a team-level activity not a leadership practice

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Leaders set the neurochemical tone for their organisations. When a leader reflects openly, team members' brains register it as a safety signal: 'If the leader can pause, examine their own decisions, and admit areas for growth, it must be safe for me to do the same.' When leaders skip reflection while mandating it for others, the brain reads the inconsistency as a threat signal: 'They don't actually believe this matters. Following the rules but not the spirit.'

Leader reflection also has a direct performance benefit. Research on executive decision-making shows that leaders who engage in regular structured reflection make better decisions, recover from mistakes faster, and are less susceptible to confirmation bias. The prefrontal cortex benefits from reflection regardless of seniority.

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Leadership Reflection Audit (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Before we ask our teams to reflect, let's be honest about our own practice. When was the last time you paused to reflect on a decision you made, how your leadership is landing, or what you're learning? Not in a formal review. Just a moment of genuine self-examination. Write down your honest answer."

Most leaders will acknowledge they reflect rarely, if at all. This is not a criticism. It is the starting point.

Phase 2: The Three Leadership Reflection Questions (15 minutes)

Introduce three reflection questions designed for leaders:

LEADERSHIP REFLECTION PROMPTS

1. "What decision did I make this week that I'm least confident about?" (This surfaces uncertainty, which leaders rarely examine.)
2. "How did my behaviour this week affect my team's energy?" (This connects leadership behaviour to team impact.)
3. "What am I avoiding?" (The most powerful of the three. Leaders often know what they're avoiding but never name it.)

Each leader reflects privately on all three questions, then shares one (their choice of which one). The sharing is the modelling: leaders demonstrating that reflection is not just for their teams.

Phase 3: Making It Visible (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"If we want our teams to reflect, they need to see us doing it. Not performatively. Authentically. What's one way you can make your reflection practice visible to your team without it feeling forced?"

Options: sharing a reflection insight in a team meeting ("Something I noticed about my own leadership this week..."), referencing a reflection in a 1:1 ("I've been reflecting on how I handle X and I want to do it differently"), or simply telling the team that you reflect and what you use ("I spend 3 minutes at the end of each day asking myself what I'd do differently").

Phase 4: Commitment (5 minutes)

Each leader commits to:

- A personal reflection practice (format and frequency)
- One visible act of reflection with their team in the next two weeks
- Using the three leadership reflection questions at least once a week

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
A leader says they don't have time to reflect	"You don't have time not to. Every unreflected decision has a compounding cost. Three minutes a day is not a time investment. It's a decision quality investment. What's one decision you made this week that an extra minute of thought would have improved?"

Leaders worry that visible reflection will make them look uncertain

"Certainty without reflection is arrogance. Your team doesn't need you to be certain about everything. They need you to be thoughtful about everything. Those are different things."

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
V4: Leadership Archetypes	V4 builds leadership self-awareness. R13 applies that self-awareness through ongoing reflection.	V4 before R13
R1: Micro-Reflection	R13 is the leadership version of R1. Leaders should use the same tools they're asking their teams to use.	Complementary
R8: Consistency Across Teams	Leaders who reflect set the tone for organisational consistency.	R13 enables R8